



YOUNG GUNS ON THE LINKS

88 | **INDIAN-AMERICAN PLAYERS ARE MAKING WAVES IN THE MEN'S PROFESSIONAL GOLF CIRCUIT IN THE US**

BY RAHUL BANERJI

N JULY AND September this year, two young gun Indian-Americans made major strides towards becoming future stars in the men's professional golf circuit in the US. The first one to step up was Akshay Bhatia, a lanky 21-year-old from Los Angeles, with 25-year-old Sahith Theegala from Orange County, California, hot on his heels.

Bhatia and Theegala are emblematic of an increasing number of Indian-Americans competing at the highest levels of junior- and collegiate golf in the US. Two years ago, New Jersey schoolgirl Megha Ganne wowed the crowd at the 2021 US Open with her feisty performance. In the same year, Natalie Srinivasan won the Annika Award for best female college golfer, while Theegala received the Fred Haskins Award for best male university golfer.

Theegala and Bhatia entered the professional ranks

in very different fashions. Theegala turned professional soon after a storied college career, while Bhatia did so as soon as he was eligible, at age 17. But both are now full-fledged PGA Tour members and have won on the circuit.

So, what separates these young men and women from the players back in India? Only two Indians have played with any real distinction on the PGA Tour circuit—Arjun Atwal and Anirban Lahiri—and they remain the only Indians to have won in a PGA Tour.

This illustrates Indian golf's pleasant as well as unfortunate sides. It is not geography or genetics but facilities and opportunities that determine a young golfer's progress. Further, compared to Europe, the US, and even Asian achievers like South Korea and Thailand, India has a long way to go in providing its young players with good platforms to realise their potential.

After his breakthrough professional win at the Fortinet Championship in Napa, California, Theegala